



YOU ARE **18 WEEKS AND 5 DAYS**

149 days to go

YOUR BABY TODAY

Your baby's hands—and feet—look quite large at this stage in pregnancy: it is as if your baby needs time to grow into them. The past few weeks have seen rapid changes in the hands and feet and it's now time for the limbs to catch up.

“Your baby's fingers and toes are fully developed and their unique prints are beginning to form.”

Your baby will be a unique individual and their fingerprints will be proof of this. The ridge patterns in the dermis that will eventually form fingerprints (and “toeprints”) are fully developed by this stage of pregnancy. These skin ridges are genetically determined and, as with most developments, are seen about a week earlier in the hands than the feet.

Your baby's sweat glands appeared in their skin in the eighth week, and will continue to increase up to 28 weeks; but they do not function until after birth. The color of your baby's skin is due to melanin, a pigment produced by “melanocytes,” specialized skin cells that have now migrated into the skin. Different skin tones are not due to differing numbers of these cells but due to the amount and shade of pigment that each cell produces. Melanin protects the skin from ultraviolet light, which damages DNA.

Although unborn babies produce melanin pigment, they do not achieve their final amount of skin pigment until well into childhood. For this reason, it follows that all newborn babies are particularly vulnerable to sunburn. Dark-skinned babies are likely to have a light skin tone when they're born.

VITAMIN E

Eating foods that are rich in vitamin E, especially avocados, boosts your immunity. Vitamin E is an antioxidant vitamin transported in oils and fats. The best known source of vitamin E is avocado, which is a great pregnancy food that's rich in monounsaturated oils (see [Good fats](#)) and potassium, and is low GI, too (see [Know your carbs](#)). Avocados are also great for starting babies on solid food, so get into the habit of buying them!

ACUPUNCTURE
